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DESIGN BRIEFS *AFTER PROGRESS*

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ABSTRACT

Design briefs can be expressions of needs articulated not only by educators but also by external actors and society more broadly. Briefs are where societal needs, expectations, wishes and desires meet the internal, local and situated logic of design and design education.

In this workshop, we aim to make an inventory of past and current design briefs and start to re-imagine them by moving beyond the taken-for-granted starting point of continued growth. We are led by the overarching question: what could a design brief become when it is actively intended to shift away from notions of design as formulated in traditions of continuous financial growth and problem-solving connected to extractivism and lost life opportunities?

INTRODUCTION

Design as a practice is highly entangled in processes and infrastructures which have been built on the logics of capitalism (Wizinsky, 2022), progress (Savransky & Lundy, 2022), and technological development (Dillet & Hatzisavvidou, 2022). Foundational elements in design's methodologies and worldviews thus carry legacies of modernism and industrialization which direct design towards certain ways of thinking and knowing. This history is sometimes evident, but also often so deeply embedded in our methods and vocabulary that it informs the fundamental values and outputs of what is designed (Gerber, 2021) even when we might try to design otherwise (DiSalvo, 2022; Abdulla, 2025). Values, lifestyles, worldviews and beliefs in which the idea of 'progress' is core have been integral to shaping design, and to the outcomes that design has been complicit in furthering. How might it be possible for design as a practice to contribute towards different and other values and evaluation criteria, when it seems that "the imperative of progress is one we cannot live with but do not know how to live without"? (Savransky & Lundy 2022, 223)

Whilst searching for ways to make visible and side-step ideals of 'progress' embedded in many design practices, there is simultaneously a need to envision and articulate skills and competencies, values and vocabularies, expectations and evaluation criteria necessary to develop approaches, methods and sensibilities for designing *after progress.*

In the context of the six-year research environment, *Design after Progress: Reimagining design histories and futures* [The Swedish Research Council, grant number 2022-02319], our inquiries seek to carefully

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untie design's entanglement with progress and to craft concrete imaginaries of a more socio-ecologically just design *after progress*. This area of research has its foundation in an ethics and politics of a broken world thinking (Jackson, 2014), where the notion of progress is brought into question (DiSalvo, 2019) through speculative and participatory explorations. This research thus involves studies and designerly engagements with landscapes and ecologies that are marked and haunted (Gordon, 2008) by the aftermath of progress. We are particularly interested in how to prefigure radical change-oriented higher education for designers and beyond, drawing on feminist theories that connect change to the socio-cultural, the ecological and the economic (Gibson-Graham, 2008) as well as to intra-active pedagogy that recognises ongoing mutual becomings between humans and more-than-humans (Lenz-Taguchi, 2012).A central part of this work is thus also to rethink and rework the ways in which education and learning is tied to progress, and to support "learning after progress" (Schildersmans, 2023). This means to find ways to support learning that seeks to open up futures and make them into a collective concern, rather than providing pathways to a future already known.

Design briefs embrace a complex conglomerate of many surprising agencies and potentials. Our interest in briefs revolves around their dual workings of being both formative scripts for where design processes start (Ruiz Munos 2020), and articulations of how 'design' itself is defined through what is called out as a design space in relation to agency, expectations, and outcomes in and of design.

Depending on contexts and practices, design briefs most certainly take on different formats and show a great diversity in approaches to design and design situations. At its most basic, the design brief always describes the aims, objectives and constraints of the design task ahead. As a consequence, it is fundamental in many and diverse areas of design, spanning over a spectrum from commercial and industrial design practices to design research and design education. How a brief is structured, articulated and operationalised can vary immensely in such a spectrum, but is in essence always a statement on what design is capable of taking on and responding to. A brief therefore needs to hold enough stability in relation to design practice to be deemed as relevant *as* design and *for* design. But a brief also needs to provide enough openness to make it possible to expand the methods and outlooks of what design can do, and how somewhat unexpected design outcomes – whether processes or products – can still be assessed, evaluated and appreciated as relevant *as design*. In this sense, a design brief is always a negotiation of both the design space and possible outcomes as well as of definitions of what design and designing is or could become.

In this workshop we invite our design peers to share, unpack, and remake existing and previous design briefs from a prefigurative perspective of articulating design abilities, competencies and outlooks that can respond to *design after progress.* We do so by building on the questions of Savransky and Lundy (2022, p. 221): "What might be at stake in affirming the possibility of learning to appraise the present otherwise, to make lives worth living and futures worth living for outside of progressive coordinates? And in one and the same breath: what are the terms of order, the evidences and the disqualifications such possibilities must question before they themselves can become perceptible?"

CONDITIONS FOR DESIGN BRIEFS

We wish to tentatively sketch out some explorative conditions for design briefs, honing in on their capacity of articulating – and expanding – notions of what designing could be. These conditions are not meant to give definitions of what a design brief is, or how it should be set up to attain certain desired design responses and outcomes (Koronis et al., 2020). They should rather be understood as hypothetical assumptions and proposals for how design briefs perform and shape notions of what design 'is' and does, and, how this can be negotiated and debated to expand and reshape understandings of design. The aim is to be attentive both to the importance of the brief as a mediator for how design is sparked into being, and to the role the brief holds in *making* definitions of design, through design (Redström, 2017).

These are conditions we ask the design community to respond to and explore together in this workshop, and to approach the engagements with design briefs as *essays* – attempts – to make present and contend with embedded notions and values of 'progress' in order to imagine what *design after progress* might entail. To, again, build on Savransky and Lundy (2022, p. 224): "The invitation to imagine an 'after' to that which was meant to have no afters, of stepping outside the imperative of progress and experimenting from its ruins rather than labouring reconstructively in its shadow, necessarily calls for a profusion of divergent wagers, of singular attempts, of essays in the etymological sense of the word."

Posing a first condition, as mentioned above, the design brief seems elemental to where *designing begins* (Wilkie & Michael, 2020). A design brief can in a commercial setting be given by a client or a marketing department to a design team to assign and initiate the work towards developing a specific design outcome (Phillips, 2004). In a design educational setting, distribution of a brief usually marks the start of a course or defined learning module in which the student should learn to handle, develop and apply various approaches, methods, processes, tools and materials through designing.

Another condition specific to design briefs is that they are often *hidden*. By that, we mean that briefs are rarely shared or made publicly accessible beyond the design team or design context in which they are acted upon. In commercial settings, the brief might even be classified as an industry secret, not allowed to be shared as it mediates new potential technology, materials, systems or concepts and thus will be stored away internally and regulated through non-disclosure agreements. In education, the design briefs written for different courses might only be accessed by students enrolled in the specific programme or course and the educators involved in the pedagogical work. These briefs are hidden by means of the regulated access to the educational digital platform. This hidden condition of briefs contributes to an occlusion of the openness that even the most specified brief carries in terms of the interpretative and dialogic relationships designers enter into when engaging in conversations with brief-givers, stakeholders and collaborators – and with trying and testing the boundaries of the brief. This points to the third condition of briefs, which is the aspect we wish to foreground in this workshop:

A third condition is that briefs are at some point always *negotiated* in one or many ways. The framing and composing of the brief can be set by various stakeholders and externals in need of design skills and competencies. Briefs are something that can be *responded* to by design, and negotiations of different kinds are integral to design responses. In a commercial setting, negotiation can take place between designer and client, or design team and company leadership, in terms of task articulation, time constraints, mandates and responsibilities, which all relate to expectations on design processes and outcomes.

In design education, negotiations take place when the brief is formulated based on what students are expected and required to learn both in regard to course syllabi and to pedagogical practices and cultures in the teaching environment – and to any further aspects and expectations brought into context by external collaboration partners. In both types of negotiation, the brief becomes an expression of how design and designing is understood in terms of where and how a design 'problem' or design space is framed and defined; what types of skills, expertise and competencies a designer or design team should have, and what kinds of processes, deliverables and outcomes design is expected to provide. By means of these various negotiations, the brief comes to work as an articulation of design spaces, design competencies, and expectations on design outcomes.

QUESTIONS IN RELATION TO BRIEF-MAKING

These conditions raise a set of questions we wish to invite participants to collaboratively make sense of:

- *As the brief is where 'design begins', and works as something that initiates design and thus partly is what makes designing possible: how can the brief be re-thought and used in redirecting design practices? How could commercial and educational design briefs be articulated to call for design practices that evolve and emerge in response to complexities and polycrisis?*

- *Since the brief frames a situation and prompts a response by calling upon design; what kind of design skills, competencies and capabilities could be envisioned and re-negotiated to articulate expectations and actions for 'designing after progress' in the format of a brief?*

- *As briefs have been characterized by the concealment of intentions and information, such as being hidden in NDA:s, learning platforms, course descriptions and inboxes, how can they be made more public to share and build upon each other's knowledges?*

- *How can practical skills in negotiating the crafting of design briefs 'after progress' be shared, and how can design educators and researchers contribute to learning situations that support learning the art of negotiating briefs? Who should and could be involved in making the framing of a brief, and how could the brief work in prefiguring practices, thus making new definitions of design?*

PROTOTYPING BRIEFS FOR A FUTURE DESIGN SCHOOL AFTER PROGRESS

We invite design researchers, practitioners, and educators interested in (re-)emerging areas within design that explore "design after progress", or design in the ruins of design, to work with design briefs as materials for re-articulating and re-negotiating design competencies, capabilities and skills, in such emerging responses that involve designerly engagements driven by care (Pennington, 2018), repair (Jackson, 2014), revival (Shove, 2012), un/making (Lindström & Ståhl, 2020), refusal (Tuck & Yang, 2014), householding (Ståhl 2023; 2024) and letting go (Lindström et al., 2024).

More specifically we ask the Nordes design community to step into a space where we together prefigure what a future design school might be like. As design methods and theories taught in many higher educational settings have been shaped within a modernist, fossil fuel dependent paradigm, these are not in sync with the demands of the transformative changes required to

redirect design (Stoddard et al., 2021). Through sharing, re-imagining and rehearsing what future briefs prospective students could be given, we will focus on post-anthropocentric and post-capitalist and other perspectives that challenge assumptions that all kinds of problems can be addressed by more design and more making (Coombs et al., 2018).

One aim of the workshop is to initiate an inventory of briefs and try to make them public, possibly as Open Educational Resources as part of striving for a connection between education and open science (de Knecht et al., 2021). This is important as it allows us to negotiate, learn and see patterns and development changes in expectations on design competencies – and also to read between the lines and search for deeply embedded historical understandings of design methodologies, skills and capabilities that need to be renegotiated. Another aim is to honour and highlight the work and craftsmanship involved in the making of design briefs, and the way that brief-making is an agonistic site of collaborative and constant negotiation of design practice and design response-abilities. An overall aspiration with the workshop is also to begin to re-imagine briefs in light of current challenges and states of design as it is evolving in response to complexities and polycrisis.

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PRACTICAL OVERVIEW OF WORKSHOP

WORKSHOP TITLE: Design Briefs after Progress

MOTIVATION: To make an inventory of design briefs and to practice how to re-imagine and re-work design briefs for *design after progress*

LENGTH & NUMBER OF PARTICIPANTS: 3 h. Minimum 5, maximum 30 participants

ETHICAL ISSUES, CONSENT AND DATA PRIVACY: Participants will be asked to sign a consent form specifically developed for Design after Progress in relation to the workshop that handles both ethical issues and data privacy.

PREFERRED SET-UP, SUPPORT NEEDED (TECHNOLOGY, MATERIALS OR OTHER ASSISTANCE: A room with the possibility to hang things on the wall using pins, tape or magnets. We need large papers (preferably a roll of butchers' paper), markers, paper, string and tape.

PREPARATIONS, AND NEEDS TO BRING: For the workshop we invite participants to bring a design brief from their own design teaching or other design practice (including commercial design, design research, etc.). Preferably the briefs should be either given by a "client" or external collaboration partner, or in some other way involve external stakeholders. The brief can be old, new, secret, annoying, curious, old, speculative and so on. The brief does not need to be submitted or shared before the workshop.

The briefs will be used during the workshop, where participants are invited to share their respective brief with each other, and to discuss itches, tensions, and possible openings in relation to what is asked of design, and what kind of competencies and skills are expected of designers in the brief. After this, participants will co-select a few briefs to continue working collaboratively on, in order to re-articulate the brief with the aim of making it a *design brief after progress*. This will include negotiating the design situations, skills, competencies and capabilities relevant for learning and practising design after progress. This will form the foundation for envisioning how a future design school would articulate an education aiming for fostering skills and providing learning environments for design after progress.

TENTATIVE PROGRAMME

INTRODUCTION (20 MINS): The workshop starts with an introduction by the workshop hosts, where we share some of the particularities for thinking and working with *design after progress* to set the scene for a future School of Design after Progress. We also introduce some of our own examples of design briefs, how we have located and worked with historical briefs and how these have sparked the outlining and aims of the workshop.

SHARE AND DISCUSS DESIGN BRIEFS (40 MINS): Participants gather for peer-work in groups of 5 to share and discuss their respective design briefs. What is the context? How did this brief come about? Who is the sender/s of the brief? Is it secret? Hidden? Where can it be found and where is it stored? What negotiations were made in relation to clients/commissioners/external stakeholders/other designers/design teachers? How were expectations on design outcomes and learning outcomes negotiated? How did students take it on? What skills and competences are practiced and asked for through these briefs? Is there something that you find difficult with the brief – what is itchy? What would you wish to change?

(Break 15 mins)

RE-DESIGN BRIEFS (50 MINS): Gather in groups to collectively (re)design one or two briefs per group for a speculative School of Design after Progress. Who are the stakeholders that will be needed in a brief that meets different and other values beyond progress? Who sets up the frame for the brief, who should be the sender? What is the assignment? What skills are asked for or needed? How are they negotiated?

PREPARE (30 MINS): Make and prepare materials for opening ceremony of the School of Design after Progress (ca 30 mins). Based on the initial briefs and the discussions in the group, choose the most interesting examples of briefs you want to make public and hang on the wall. Write down the re-designed briefs and hang on the wall.

(Break 15 mins)

PREFIGURING THE OPENING CEREMONY OF THE SPECULATIVE SCHOOL OF DESIGN AFTER PROGRESS (30 MINS): Sharing of the re-designed briefs. As a collective prefigurative speculation, we propose articulations of the skills, competencies and approaches required to learn for *designing after progress.* This concludes with a ceremonial opening of the speculative School of Design after Progress.